

AICloudStrategist

Credibility Badges + Remote Communities

Purpose: Trust-compounding activities that make every cold email, every DM, every blog post 2-3x more credible – without requiring in-person presence or large cash outlay.

Budget reality: We are bootstrapping to first customer. This document is strictly 0 options plus one exception at Month 3+ if revenue supports it.

Section 1 – AWS Partner Network: SKIP (too expensive for our stage)

What we discovered: - Registered tier: technically free but provides zero marketing value (no logo, no directory listing, no badge we can display) - Confirmed tier and above: **\$2,500/year APN fee** (~2.1 lakh/year) - Requires 2+ AWS certifications at ~\$150 per exam to qualify for Select tier - Plus ongoing MRR commitments to maintain

Our decision: Skip AWS Partner Network until Month 6+ when revenue makes the 2L/year fee an obvious ROI call. At our current stage, 2L on marketing signal vs. 2L on 4 more months of runway is no contest – pick runway.

When to revisit: Once we have 3 paying customers delivering verified savings AND are actively losing enterprise deals to firms asking “are you AWS Partner certified?” Not before.

Section 2 – Microsoft AI Cloud Partner Program (actually free, apply now)

What it is: - Microsoft’s partner program (formerly MPN) has a free base tier as of 2026 - No annual fee required to get a Partner ID - Gives: Partner ID for marketing collateral, limited Azure credits, access to marketing resources - Does NOT give: “Solutions Partner” badges (those require paid Action Pack at ~\$500/year + skill attainment)

Is it worth it for us? - **Yes** for the Partner ID alone – we serve Azure workloads per services.html, so having a Microsoft Partner ID in our marketing footer is a legitimate signal - Zero cost, ~45 minutes to set up

How to apply: 1. Go to <https://partner.microsoft.com/en-US/partnership> 2. Sign in with Microsoft account (Rajiv can create one on support@aicloudstrategist.com) 3. Click “Join the Microsoft AI Cloud Partner Program” 4. Fill organisation details (legal entity, address, tax info) 5. Accept partner agreement 6. Receive Partner ID within ~24 hours

What we put on the site: “Microsoft AI Cloud Partner Program Member” in footer of /services.html (small text, no big logo claim)

Action: Rajiv applies this week. 45 min. 0.

Section 3 – Google Cloud Partner Advantage (free application, worth trying)

What it is: - Google Cloud’s partner program has no disclosed base fee - Application-based – they evaluate fit - Gets you: Partner ID, co-sell introductions if they see fit, access to training materials

Realistic expectation: At our size (solo founder, no existing GCP deals) Google may not approve us for the main partner tier. There is a “Partner Skills” portal that anyone can access for free which is the fallback.

Action: 1. Apply at <https://cloud.google.com/partners> – takes 30 min 2. If approved: Partner ID in the footer 3. If rejected: note and move on, reapply at Month 6

Action: Rajiv applies this week. 30 min. 0.

Section 4 – FinOps Foundation (community Slack is free; full membership is not a fit for consultants)

What we learned: - FinOps Foundation’s **Practitioner** membership is free but specifically for people working IN finance teams – consultants like us don’t qualify - Vendor membership is paid (tiered, starts at ~\$8K/year) – way too expensive - **BUT** the community Slack is free to join as an observer/contributor via

<https://www.finops.org/community/community-slack/>

What works for us: - Join community Slack as an individual contributor (not as a company) – Anushka joins using her email, not as “AICloudStrategist” - Be known as a helpful voice in channels for 3-6 months - Eventually propose content for their blog/podcast – this is the real credibility payoff

Why this is worth time even though we don’t get a badge: - FinOps practitioners ARE our buyers – they’re inside mid-to-large companies managing cost - Personal reputation in that Slack = direct pipeline - Being cited by the FinOps Foundation (even a quote in a case study) is worth more than any paid partner badge

Practitioner certification (\$250 exam): - Worth considering at Month 2 once we have runway - Not required to be effective; required if we want to cite “FinOps Certified” on the site - Cheap enough to revisit soon. Not urgent today.

Action: Anushka joins Slack this week. Lurks for 2 weeks, starts contributing in week 3.

Section 5 – AWS User Group virtual participation (free, actually useful)

These are volunteer-run communities. They are NOT AWS Partner Network – they are just people who like AWS meeting to talk about AWS. Completely free to join.

Join all three immediately (10 min each): - **AWS User Group Delhi:** <https://www.meetup.com/aws-user-group-delhi/> - **AWS User Group Bengaluru:** <https://www.meetup.com/awsugblr/> - **AWS User Group Mumbai:** <https://www.meetup.com/awsugmum/>

What to do after joining: - Attend the next virtual event in each (usually 1 hour evening IST, monthly) - Ask ONE thoughtful question in the session Q&A - DM the organiser after 2 events with: “I have a 15-min talk on Indian FinOps patterns – interested?” - Getting on the speaker roster = real credibility signal

Time commitment: 3-5 hours/month. **Cost:** 0.

Success criteria: Speaker slot at 1 AWS User Group event in 3-6 months. Each talk converts to 2-5 pipeline leads.

Section 6 – AWS Community Builder program (free, application-based, worth applying)

What it is: - AWS’s recognition program for technical content creators (bloggers, open-source contributors, community organisers) - Applications open twice per year – check <https://aws.amazon.com/developer/community/community-builders/> - Gets you: Community Builder title (displayed on site + email signature), small AWS credits (\$500/year), some closed-Slack access, occasional invites to AWS internal programs

Is it a fit? - We have 11 AWS-relevant blog posts - Anushka is the author voice - Application essay is about “impact on the community” – our blog is a legitimate contribution

Realistic odds: 1 in 4 applications get accepted. Worth applying since it’s free. If rejected, reapply in 6 months when we have more posts + verified traction.

Action: Anushka applies when applications open next (check cycle on AWS site). If open now, apply this week.

Section 7 – Indie Hackers (free, high-signal for solo-founder audience)

What it gets us: - Profile on indiehackers.com linked from our posts - Consistent presence in the Indie Hackers newsletter if we publish quality posts - Network effect with other solo-founder buyers (our secondary ICP)

Setup: 1. Create Anushka’s Indie Hackers profile 2. Bio: “Founder, AICloudStrategist. Cloud cost consultancy for Indian mid-market. Writes at aicloudstrategist.com/blog” 3. Add aicloudstrategist.com to the profile site field 4. First post: repurpose gain-share blog post (we have draft in 07-reddit-posts.md)

Cadence: 1 quality post per month. Comment on 5 other posts per week. ~2 hours/month.

Cost: 0.

Section 8 – HackerNews (opportunistic)

Rajiv's existing HN account (needs 90+ days old + some activity). Use for: - Submitting our best blog post when something lands well on Reddit (social proof stacks) - Commenting on related HN threads to build karma in AWS / FinOps / India-tech conversations

Don't: Submit blog posts to HN until a post has already proven on Reddit/IH. HN is unforgiving for cold submissions.

Cost: 0.

Section 9 – Podcast guest appearances (free, high-compound credibility)

Target podcasts (Indian tech / startup): - Matrix Moments (by Matrix Partners India) – VC-adjacent, talks to founders - Prime Venture Partners podcast – Indian startup operator stories - Masters of Scale India – occasional Indian operator episodes - The Seen and Unseen by Amit Varma – broader but occasionally tech - Cloud Wars (global but Indian guests welcome) - Jatin Hansraj's podcast / specific FinOps / cloud podcasts

How to pitch: - Find host's email/Twitter DM - Pitch a specific episode topic – NOT "have me on your show" - Example: "Would be happy to talk about why Indian mid-market cloud bills double before they get optimised – I have specific INR numbers from 12 audits" - Offer to share blog post data they can reference

Realistic conversion: 10 pitches → 1-2 yeses → 1 episode recorded in 2-3 months. Each episode = sustained inbound for 6-12 months.

Cost: 0 beyond the 30-min recording time.

Action: Add this as a Month 2 task. Not sprint-urgent but worth starting pitches now.

Section 10 – Guest posts on mid-tier publications (free, high-compound)

Target publications (Indian tech press, will take well-written guest posts): - Inc42 – takes founder-authored op-eds on startup topics (submission: editorial@inc42.com) - YourStory – similar (submission: yourstory.com/contribute or via editor email) - The Ken – paywall but highly respected; hard to get in but possible - MediaNama – tech-policy angle; takes practitioner pieces - AnalyticsIndiaMag – takes FinOps/AI/cloud posts

Pitch: - Adapt one of our 11 blog posts to their house style - Submit via their published editorial email - Expect 30-60% acceptance if the post is genuinely good and fits their audience

Biggest win: An Inc42 byline with "Anushka B, Founder, AICloudStrategist" in bio = lifetime credibility signal on our site.

Action: Draft 1 guest post pitch in Week 2 of sprint. Submit to Inc42. Parallel track – don't block on acceptance.

Revised tracker actions (replaces earlier AWS Partner Network advice)

```
# DELETE old task if exists
vk done <task_id_for_AWS_Partner_Network> # with description "skipping, too expensive, revisit Month 6"

# Add the right ones
vk add 7 "Apply Microsoft AI Cloud Partner Program (free, 45 min)" "https://partner.microsoft.com/en-US/partne
Partner ID for /services.html footer"
vk label <id> rajiv-owns

vk add 7 "Apply Google Cloud Partner Advantage (free)" "https://cloud.google.com/partners – 30 min; may reject
size but free to try"
vk label <id> rajiv-owns

vk add 7 "Join FinOps Foundation community Slack (free)" "https://www.finops.org/community/community-slack/ –
individual, lurk 2 weeks then contribute"
vk label <id> waiting-on-anushka

vk add 7 "Join AWS User Group Delhi + Bengaluru + Mumbai (meetup.com, free)" "Virtual events only; aim: get on
speaker roster at 1 of them in 3 months"
vk label <id> waiting-on-anushka
```

```
vk add 7 "Apply AWS Community Builder when applications open" "https://aws.amazon.com/developer/community/builders/ – check cycle; free, recognition-based"
vk label <id> waiting-on-anushka

vk add 7 "Create Indie Hackers profile + first post" "https://www.indiehackers.com/ – gain-share post from 07-posts.md"
vk label <id> waiting-on-anushka

vk add 7 "Pitch 3 podcasts with specific episode topics" "Matrix Moments, Prime VP, AnalyticsIndiaMag – topic: 'Indian mid-market cloud bills double before optimised'"
vk label <id> rajiv-owns

vk add 7 "Submit guest post to Inc42 (editorial@inc42.com)" "Adapt RI-coverage post to their house style; byli Anushka B, Founder"
vk label <id> claudes-owns
```

Total investment: zero (until Month 3)

Everything in this doc is either free or application-based. No cash outlay until: - FinOps Certified Practitioner exam (\$250 / ~21K) – Month 2 optional - AWS Partner Network Confirmed (\$2,500/year / ~2.1L) – Month 6+ if ROI obvious

Until then, credibility compounds via content + community + being genuinely helpful. That is the bootstrap consultant's playbook – nothing fancier works.